

4

BUILDING YOUR PROTECTION

You don't want to discover you have the wrong policy when you reach the hospital. Difficult to negotiate, buying a medical cover is crucial to the health of your money box.

I remember meeting a colleague some years back who'd been missing for a week. 'Had a nice holiday?' I asked enviously. 'Nope,' he said, 'medical emergency – mum had a stroke.' And then he cracked up. All through the hospital stay, he said, he was replaying what I would keep telling him over and over: You must have a medical cover.

He said he meant to do it but kept putting it off. He was also banking on the workplace cover he thought covered him and his dependants. But he realized at the hospital that the company, in an austerity move, had reduced the cover to his nuclear family and chucked out his dependent parents from the group cover.

He dipped into his savings, of course. But the thought that the entire expense running into several lakhs of rupees could have come out of a policy left him really upset. It's like discovering you've forgotten your mobile charger just as you step into the aircraft for a week-long trip, he said. It's that 'Oh shoot!' moment in your life.

It isn't just journalists who don't buy cover, a roomful of financial-sector CEOs once admitted to not having cover. It was the annual Mint Mutual Fund event and before the event began we were sitting in the antechamber waiting for